China

January 6, 1950

Personal

Dear Arthur:

Events have moved so rapidly with the President's and Acheson's statement about Formosa that it seems to me that there is not left any chance for constructive action, and it is a case where we must cry over spilled milk!

I had prepared quite a memorandum on the possibilities of taking Formosa to the United Nations Assembly on the theory that Formosa was a non-self-governing territory, and that the best solution might be an interim period at least of trusteeship under Article 77, providing for trusteeship of "territories which may be detached from enemy states as a result of the Second World War", and on the theory that the Charter obligation to treat the welfare of the inhabitants as paramount cut across any Cairo Declaration.

Obviously the present situation was not foreseen at Cairo or Potsdam, and it seems to me little short of scandalous for us to adopt the theory that Formosa is already a part of China and that, therefore, the Formosans must be subjected to the cruel fate of being the final battleground between the Red regime and the Nationalist Army.

It seems to me that the tragedy of Formosa is the Formosans. There is a normal population of about six million, probably now swelled to around seven million. In other words, the population is about the same as Australia and greater than that of at least twenty nations members of the United Nations. They have a distinctive economic, social and cultural life and for about two generations (55 years) have had no political ties with China. From the standpoint of economic development, literacy, etc., they are much in advance of most of China.

Acheson's statement of yesterday attempted to strike a very high moral note about respecting the integrity of other countries. I would think that we ought to

have had some respect for the six or seven million people in Formosa who, ever since Cairo, have been dealt with from the standpoint of the strategy and prestige of great powers without regard to their own welfare or desires.

In the case of Korea, the Japanese mandated islands and the Italian colonies, we brought the situations before the United Nations to deal with in accordance with the Charter principle of the welfare of the peoples involved. And the final decisions were decisions of the United Nations. It is quite true that we turned over Formosa to the Nationalists and turned over the Kuriles to Russia without waiting for a treaty, but I don't think that it is merely a "lawyer's quibble" to say that unless there is either treaty action or United Nations action, the change is not finalized. Certainly I would think it right to keep that chance alive when it is the only chance of saving six or seven million innocent people from a very cruel fate.

However, as I say, I think this is all academic now because of the finality of the President's and Acheson's statements and the fact that probably at this late date the United Nations would resent having the problem dumped in its lap.

Faithfully yours,

The Honorable Arthur H. Vandenberg,
United States Senate,
Washington, D. C.